

Raphaël URFIN

Centre de Sciences des Données, 45 rue d'Ulm – 75005 Paris – France

About me

I am a second year PhD student at École Normale Supérieure - PSL in Paris supervised by Giulio Biroli (ENS) and Marc Mézard (Bocconi University) working on the theory of diffusion models. My background is in theoretical physics.

Education

- PhD in Physics** **ENS-PSL, Paris**
• *Subject: Generative Diffusion and Statistical Physics* **2025 - 2028(exp.)**
LPENS & Centre de Sciences des Données
Supervisors: Giulio Biroli (ENS) and Marc Mézard (Bocconi University)
- ENS Diploma** **ENS-PSL, Paris**
• *Interdisciplinary Diploma validating my studies at ENS.* **2021-2025**
- M2 ICFP Theoretical Physics Track** **ENS-PSL, Paris**
• *First Class Honors, 17.38/20* **2023 - 2024**
Relevant classes: Advanced Statistical Physics, Disordered Systems, Machine Learning.
- M1 ICFP** **ENS-PSL, Paris**
• *First Class Honors, 17.8/20* **2022 - 2023**
Relevant classes: Phase Transitions, Introduction to Quantum Field Theory, General Relativity.
- Bachelor in Physics and Mathematics** **ENS-PSL, Paris**
• *First Class Honors, 17.38/20 (Physics) and 16.36/20 (Mathematics)* **2021 - 2022**

Publications

* denotes equal contribution.

Preprints

- **Raphaël Urfin***, Tony Bonnaire*, Giulio Biroli, Marc Mézard.
Double Descent and Malign Overfitting in Diffusion Models.
arXiv:2609.26392 (2026). <https://arxiv.org/abs/2609.26392>

Conference Proceedings

- Tony Bonnaire*, **Raphaël Urfin***, Giulio Biroli, Marc Mézard.
Why Diffusion Models Don't Memorize: The Role of Implicit Dynamical Regularization in Training.
NeurIPS 2025, **Best Paper Award (4 papers among +20000 submissions)**
Advances in Neural Information Processing Systems (NeurIPS) 38, 141266-141286
Selected for the JSTAT special issue *Machine Learning 2026: J. Stat. Mech.* (2026) 084007.

Conferences, Workshops and Seminars

Invited Talks

- **Generative Memory Lab, Donders Institute** **Radboud University, Netherlands (Online)**
Invited Seminar **September 2026**
- **LemanTH 2026** **Lausanne, Switzerland**
Workshop **April 2026**

- **Vitelli's Group Meeting** **Online**
March 2026
Group meeting (non-reciprocal p-spins)
- **Scattering Club, Data Science for Astrophysics group @ LPENS** **Online**
February 2026
Invited Seminar (1 hour)
- **Voxel51 Best of NeurIPS 2025** **Online**
January 2026
Invited Seminar (30 min)
- **Centre de Sciences des Données Internal Seminar** **Paris, France**
December 2025
Invited Seminar (1 hour)
- **Machine Learning & Signal Processing @ ENS Lyon** **Lyon, France**
November 2025
Invited Seminar (1 hour)

Contributed Talks.....

- **Journées de Physique Statistique 2026** **Paris, France**
January 2026
Conference (4-min flash talk)
- **EurIPS 2025** **Copenhagen, Denmark**
December 2025
Conference (poster + 13-min oral)
- **NeurIPS in Paris 2025** **Paris, France**
November 2025
Workshop (poster + 10-min oral)
- **StatPhys 29** **Florence, Italy**
July 2025
Conference (15-min talk)
- **Youth in High Dimensions** **Trieste, Italy**
July 2025
Workshop (15-min talk)
- **Journées de Physique Statistique 2025** **Paris, France**
January 2025
Conference (4-min flash talk)

Summer Schools.....

- **Beg Rohu Summer School of Statistical Physics** **Beg Rohu, France**
June 2025 & June 2026
Summer School
 - **2026 Edition (Optimization and Control of Nonequilibrium Systems):** Lectures by international researchers (e.g. G. Peyré, G. Rotskoff ...). Presented a poster on Memorization/Generalization in diffusion models.
 - **2025 Edition (Learning with Machines, Physics and Mind):** Lectures on Machine Learning and Statistical Physics by international researchers (e.g., Yann LeCun, Julia Kempe, Stéphane Mallat, Marc Mézard ...). Presented a poster on Memorization/Generalization in diffusion models.
- **Complex and Glassy Systems** **Cargese, France**
July 2024
Summer School
 - Lectures on Statistical Physics and interdisciplinary applications by international researchers (e.g. Marc Mézard, Eric Vanden-Eijnden, Valentina Ros, Guy Bunin).

Awards and Grants

- 2025: Recipient of one of the four best paper awards at NeurIPS 2025. **(4 papers out of 20,000+ submissions)**
- 2025: CDSN, Competitive PhD scholarship for ENS students

Reviewing

- Machine Learning Workshops: EurIPS 2025 Workshop Principles of Generative Modeling (PriGM), ICLR 2026 Workshop DeLTa, ICLR 2026 Workshop Sci4DL.
- Machine Learning Journals: TMLR

Skills

- Languages: French (Native), English (Fluent), Italian (Fluent).
- Software skills: Python (Pytorch), Matlab, Latex.

Teaching Experience

- TA Machine Learning (M2, Master ICFP, ENS-PSL), 11 hours, taught in English with Marc Lelarge and Leonardo Defilippis. Spring 2026.
- TA Mathematics Tutoring for first-year students in Physics at ENS, 36 hours, taught in French with Amir-Kian Kashani-Poor. Fall 2025.
- TA Stochastic Processes for Physics (M1 level, Master ICFP, ENS-PSL), 16 hours, taught in English with Marylou Gabri  . Fall 2025.
- "Kh  lles" (Preparation for the oral exams of French "Grandes   coles") in Mathematics and Physics for Classes Pr  paratoires PC, Lyc  e Stanislas (2022–2024).

Relevant Experience

- **Statistical Physics and Diffusion Models** **Bocconi University, Milano, Italy**
Research Internship *February 2025-May 2025*
 - Supervisor: Marc M  zard, Department of Computing Sciences.
 - Subject: The Memorization/Generalization transition in diffusion models.
 - Resulted in a publication accepted at NeurIPS 2025
- **Statistical Physics and Diffusion Models** **  cole Normale Sup  rieure-PSL, France**
Research Internship *April 2024-January 2025*
 - Supervisor: Giulio Biroli, Centre de Sciences des Donn  es.
 - Subject: The effect of implicit regularization in diffusion models.
- **Emergent behaviors in large ecosystems** **University of Cambridge, UK**
Research Internship *January-July 2023*
 - Supervisor: Camille Scalliet, Soft Matter Group, Department of Applied Mathematics and Theoretical Physics.
 - Using tools from disordered systems (Cavity Method, Random Matrix Theory...) to understand emergent collective behaviors in ecological systems.